Gorbachev said he regretted that I couldn’t stay on and finish the job, and I have to admit there was a part of me that wanted to do that. But I had enormous faith in George Bush, and I knew the country was in good hands.

The next five weeks passed quickly—lots of packing, my farewell address, a succession of parties, and various final decisions.

Despite appeals from their supporters, and despite my own sympathies, I reaffirmed my decision not to give presidential pardons to John Poindexter, Bud McFarlane, and Oliver North. I still felt the law had to be allowed to take its course.

This was an especially emotional time for Nancy and me. For eight years, the White House had been our home. From around the nation, members of the White House staff and others in the administration had come to Washington to be part of our team, and we had become like a family. Now it was time to move on and we all felt sadness about it.

I’ve always thought of the presidency as an institution of which presidents are granted only temporary custody; now my custody was coming to an end and the hardest part was having to say goodbye to those who had helped me carry out my responsibilities and had always been there to help us in difficult personal times.

During the final week, many of these talented and hard-working people came to the East Room for one final good-bye. Nancy tried to thank everyone for a lovely enameled box that had been given to her, but couldn’t get through. I managed a little better, but not much. As I looked into the faces of those gathered there, I couldn’t help but think about what they had sacrificed on our behalf. So many late nights in the office, so many weekends at work away from home, pagers going off at all hours, meals skipped, telephone calls in the middle of the night, vacations abruptly canceled, toddlers’ birthday parties missed, and so